



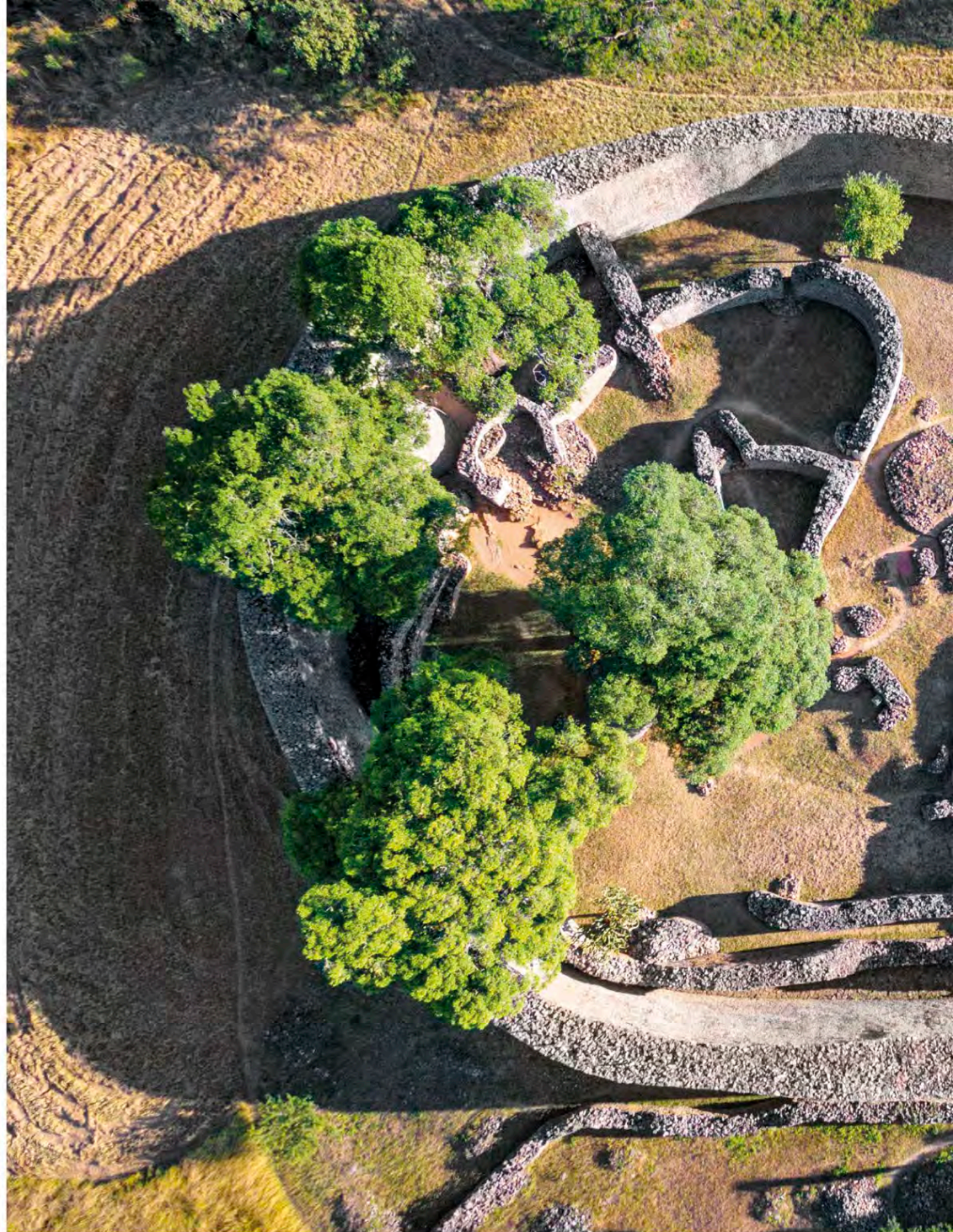
Great Zimbabwe

The ruined capital of the medieval Kingdom of Zimbabwe, once linked to King Solomon and the Queen of Sheba

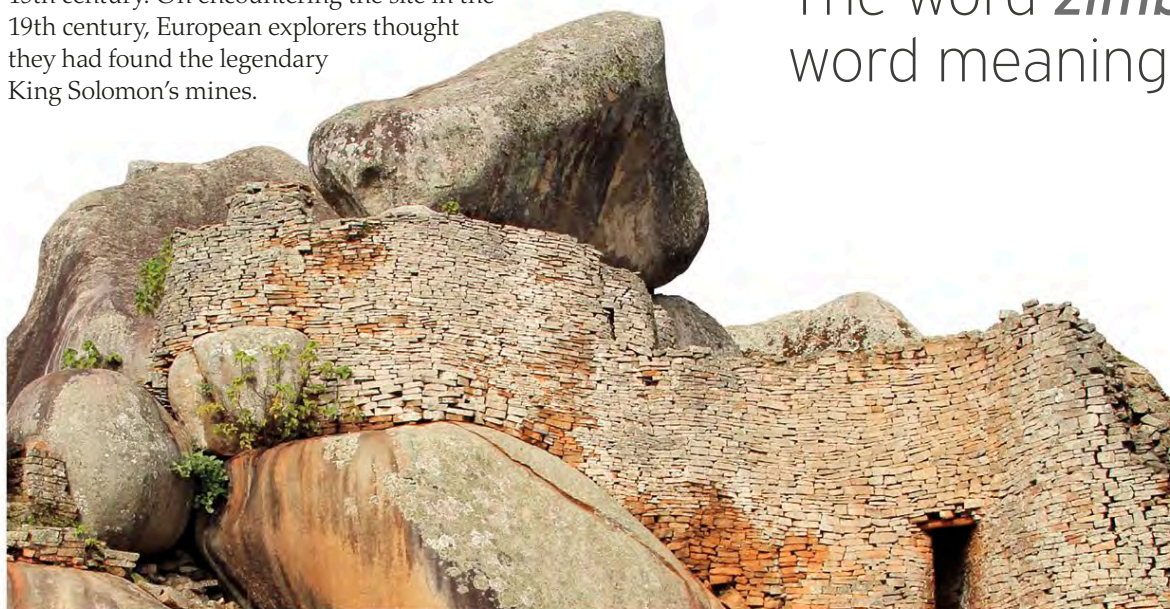
Extending over 3 square miles (8 square km) near the town of Masvingo in the eastern hills of Zimbabwe, the stone ruins of Great Zimbabwe are among the oldest and largest man-made structures in sub-Saharan Africa. Great Zimbabwe was built by the Shona—a population of Bantu people—between the 11th and 15th centuries. The site is divided into three main areas: the Hill Complex, the Great Enclosure, and the Valley Ruins. The Hill Complex and Great Enclosure are characterized by extensive stonework, comprising granite bricks laid without mortar. They also feature the *daga* (earthen and mud-brick) buildings that dominate the Valley Ruins, where thousands of goldsmiths, potters, weavers, blacksmiths, and stonemasons once lived.

A center of trade

Archaeological finds from Persia and China suggest that Great Zimbabwe was a great trading center, its wealth built on the gold and copper mines that pepper the area. However, distinctive soapstone bird carvings, known as birds of heaven and thought to represent messengers from *Mwari* (God), suggest the site also had religious significance. Great Zimbabwe was abandoned in the 15th century. On encountering the site in the 19th century, European explorers thought they had found the legendary King Solomon's mines.



The word **zimbabwe** is a Shona word meaning “**stone houses**”



◀ BOULDERS AND BLOCKS

The stone walls at Great Zimbabwe were built using boulders and granite slabs from the surrounding hills, broken to be made portable and laid in layers without the use of mortar.